

Session 2: Genesis 2-5 as the Introduction to the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- Jesus’ Bible was a three-part collection of scrolls called the TaNaK. (TaNaK is a designation for the Hebrew Bible taken from the first letter of its three major sections. T stands for *Torah*, which is Hebrew for “instruction”; N is for *Nevi'im*, meaning “prophets”; and K is for *Ketuvim*, meaning “writings.”)
- The Bible is like a patchwork quilt where each piece plays a part in the unified work.

The TaNaK as a Composite Unity

The Hebrew Bible is a set of ancient Israelite scrolls that were formed into an editorial unity over the course of their composition and collection. The three-part macro design dates to somewhere in the 3rd-2nd century B.C. This order is preserved in modern Jewish tradition and is well attested in Second Temple Jewish texts and the New Testament.

Sections	Scrolls
Torah (The Law)	Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy
Nevi'im (The Prophets)	Former Prophets: Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings
	Latter Prophets: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadaiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zaphaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi
Ketuvim (The Writings)	Psalms, Job, Proverbs, Ruth, Song of Songs, Ecclesiastes, Lementations, Esther [The <i>Megillot</i>], Daniel, Ezra, Nehemiah, Chronicles
Three-Part Collection of the Hebrew Bible. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

Jesus Refers to This Three-Part Design

When Jesus alludes to the order of the Hebrew Bible, he assumes a three-part design, which agrees with other contemporary Jewish authors who allude to the ordered sections.

Luke 24:44 NIV

This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Torah of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms.

The “blessed one” of [Psalm 1](#) is portrayed as the ideal Joshua seen in [Joshua 1:7-8](#), “one who meditates on the Torah day and night,” which results in success and a prosperous way.

Luke 11:51 NIV

Therefore, this generation will be held responsible for the blood of all the prophets that has been shed since the beginning of the world, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the sanctuary.

Abel was murdered by Cain in [Genesis 4](#), and Zechariah son of Jehoiadah was murdered by Joash in [2 Chronicles 24](#), which corresponds to the TaNaK order.

Other published texts in this time period also refer to the three-part design of the TaNaK.

“Many great teachings have been given to us through the Law [Torah], and the Prophets [Nevi'im], and the others that follow them [Ketuvim] ... So my grandfather Yeshua devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other scrolls of our Ancestors.”

Prologue to the Wisdom of Ben Sirach

“The scrolls of Moses, the words of the prophets, and of David.”

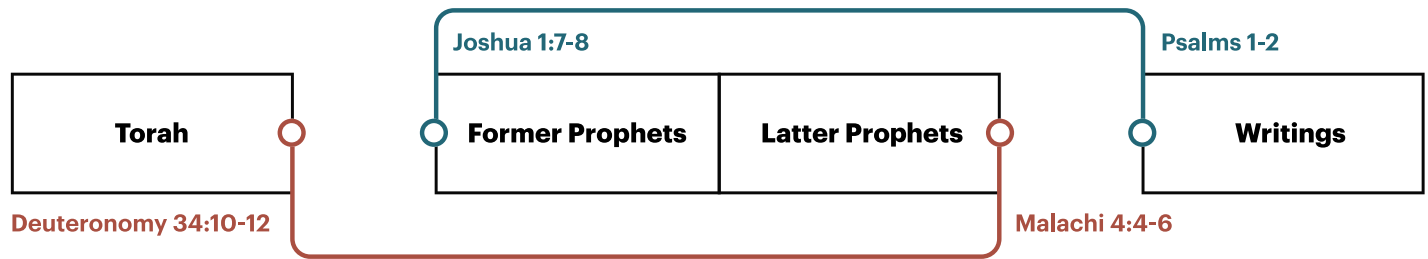
Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT)

“The laws and the oracles given by inspiration through the prophets and the Psalms, and the other scrolls whereby knowledge and piety are increased and completed.”

Philo of Alexandria (De Vita Contempletiva, 25)

The Editorial Design of the TaNaK

The three-part shape of the Hebrew Bible isn't simply a matter of arrangement. Rather, the books themselves have been designed to fit into this particular shape. If you look at the editorial seams of the major sections (remember the technology was papyrus or leather scrolls), you'll find intentional design clues at the beginning and ending of these sections.



Tanak Editorial Design. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Seam 1: The Final Sentences of the Torah and the Opening Sentences of the Nevi'im

- Deuteronomy 34:10-12: Anticipation of a coming Moses-like prophet who was promised but never came.
- Joshua 1:1-9: God's appointed leader, Joshua, who will lead the people into the promised land, must meditate on the Torah day and night to find success.

Seam 2: The Final Sentences of the Nevi'im and the Opening Sentences of the Ketuvim

- Malachi 4:4-6: Anticipation of a coming Elijah-like prophet who will call the people back to the Torah and restore the hearts of Israel before the Day of the Lord.
- Psalms 1-2: The righteous one who will be vindicated in the final judgment is one who meditates on the Torah day and night to find success (Ps. 1). This righteous one is the future messianic king from the line of David, who is appointed by God to rule the nations and overcome evil once and for all (Ps. 2).

The Hebrew Bible as a Family Quilt

A quilt is made of many pre-existing materials and consists of individual pieces (like the Eden story or the Abraham stories), collections of pieces (like the laws at Mount Sinai or the Psalms), or entire images (like the books of Ruth or Esther). These earlier materials can be incorporated into the collection as they stand, or they can be editorially reshaped to fit the new context. But, and this is the key point, it is this new overall context of the final quilt that gives each individual piece its meaning when viewed in light of the whole. Regardless of the meaning of any individual piece, the entire quilt is now the proper frame of reference for understanding every smaller piece.



In the case of Genesis 2-5 (the focus of this class), we must ask ourselves at every step of our reading: What is the meaning that is intended by the authors who formed the final shape of the TaNaK, as far as we can discern it? For the authors, Genesis 1-11 formed an introduction to the entire TaNaK. In this section of Scripture, we find the basic themes, vocabulary, and plot elements that will be developed throughout the rest of the collection.

Reflection Question

How is the Hebrew Bible like a family quilt? What might the patches, or the whole quilt, represent?